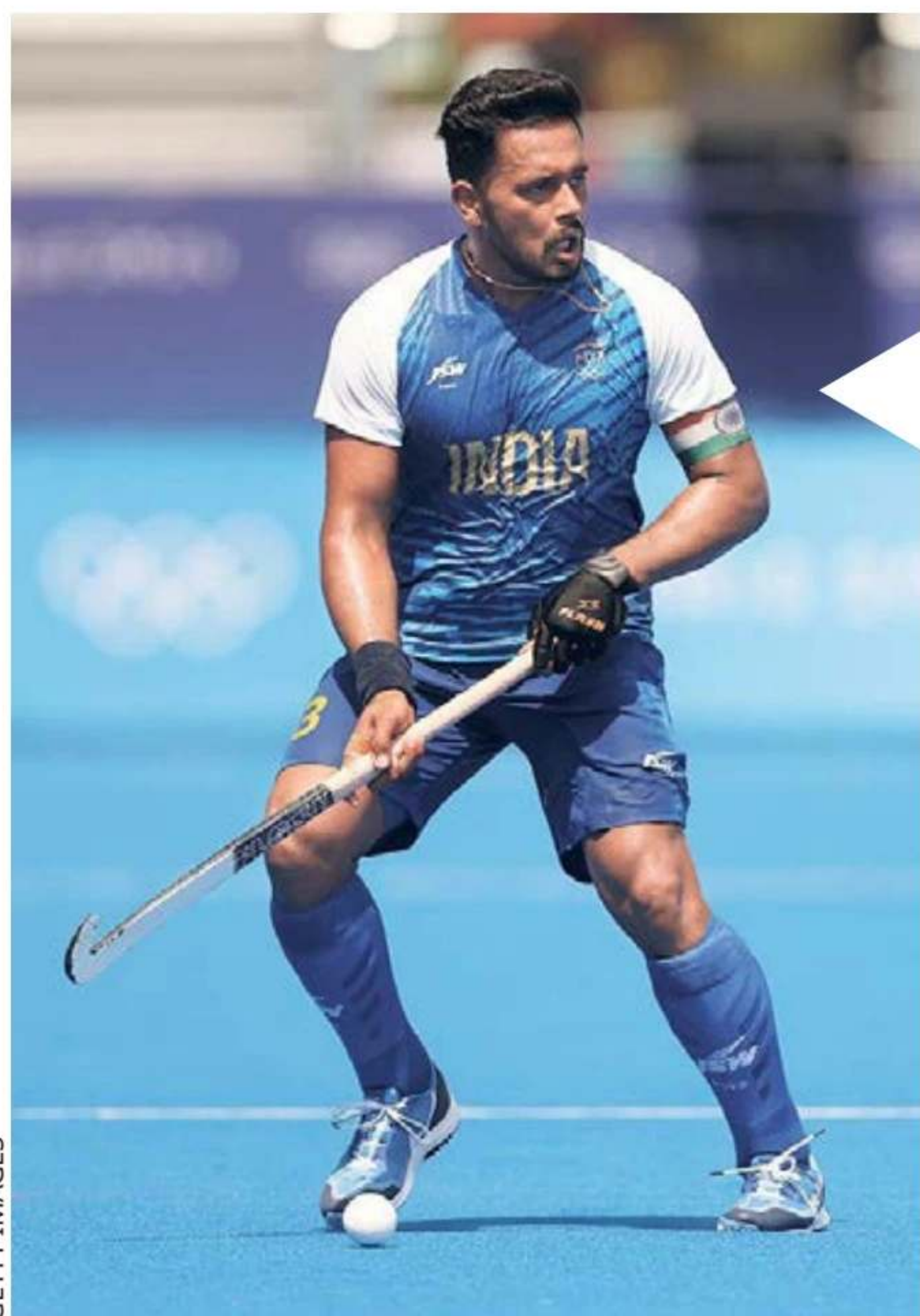


BATTLEGROUND HIL



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THE MEN'S HOCKEY INDIA LEAGUE IS BACK AFTER SEVEN YEARS, WITH EIGHT TEAMS COMPETING TO TAKE HOME THE CROWN. THIS IS HOW THE TEAMS AND THEIR KEY PLAYERS LOOK LIKE AHEAD OF THE SEASON OPENER ON DECEMBER 28.

Key player — **Harmanpreet Singh**

₹78 lakh

Soorma Hockey Club

Soorma Hockey Club, based in Punjab, went big on defenders, spending ₹1.6 crore — the most by any team at the auction. Indian skipper Harmanpreet Singh fetched top money and will bring plenty of goals to the team with his ace drag flicking skills.

Soorma has experience throughout its core, with Vincent Vanasch, Harmanpreet, Vivek Sagar Prasad, Victor Wegnez, Jonas de Geus and Gurjant Singh. Belgian Jeroen Baart, who previously coached his country's U-21 boys and in the top division of the Dutch league, has been tasked with coaching duties.

Key player — **Abhishek Nain**

₹72 lakh

Rarh Bengal Tigers

While most teams spent big on drag flickers, the Bengal Tigers made India forward Abhishek Nain its top pick. Colin Batch, who has coached Australia to international success, will helm the coaching reins.

The team was dealt a cruel blow when goalkeeper and Paris Olympic gold medallist Pirmin Blaak withdrew from the tournament due to injury. The management shelled out a premium on drag flicker Jugraj Singh and Rupinder Pal Singh (₹12.5 lakh), with the latter having retired from internationals in 2021.

The 34-year-old has been playing club hockey in the Netherlands and will be keen to show people back home that he's still got it. They also have top international stars Sam Lane (New Zealand), another penalty corner expert, and Belgians Florent van Aubel and Gauthier Boccard, along with Sukhjeet Singh.

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